

A Man of Few Words

He never imagined it would end this way. But that's just my nature. God has burdened me for eternity to carry souls to be judged in His court, and like all, I must obey. Humans are cruel they make my job harder than it needs to be. You'd think that for the death dealer, a soul might weigh like eternity. But surprisingly, it doesn't.

Humans always fascinated me, ever since Adam first stepped foot into this world. They never fail to surprise me especially at the end. They try so hard, even when the end is inevitable. Why are they so... so stubborn? Anyway, I'm getting off track. As I was saying, humans fascinate me. They do so much with what little time they have. They waste it, mostly, trying to do something. Always up to something, like Dr. Duncan MacDougall in 1907, determined that a soul weighs precisely 21 grams.

That was the first time I laughed in millennia. Imagine me, Death, laughing! I found it absurd when he measured the soul's weight. Twenty-one grams! Maybe it's their absurdity that I've come to love or be endlessly puzzled by. Only if they knew... Of course, I don't know how much a soul weighs either. You know why? Because it's simply not my job. I don't weigh or balance I gather. I collect. I ferry. But I will tell you how much their hearts weigh.

Actually, I can't tell you exactly how much it weighs either. But trust me, it's a lot. Much more than a soul. Humans burden their hearts with all sorts of things love, despair, regrets. At least that's what I used to think: meaningless clutter. Until I met them.

Faiza and Ibtisam.

Faiza... now she was different. A hopeless romantic. I don't say that lightly. She wrote poems on receipts, on the back of grocery lists, on the margins of bills she never paid on time. She believed in the kind of love that burned slowly and endlessly, like a lantern in a storm. Faiza tried to welcome me once—twice, actually. But it just wasn't her time. She always had this strange awareness of me. Like she could hear the rustle of my coat or feel the chill of my shadow before I came.

Once, she stood at the edge of her apartment balcony during a thunderstorm, arms wide open, whispering, "If you must come, then come beautifully." I wanted to tell her, Not today, Faiza. But I cannot speak unless it is their time. God's rule, not mine.

She used to say to Ibtisam, "I don't need you to love me back. I just want to be someone you think of when you hear our song on a lonely road."

And Ibtisam... Well, I came for him. I think he was expecting me. Maybe not consciously, but deep down, he knew.

Just two days earlier, he managed to slip through my fingers in a bus crash. Me—Death—slipped! He survived with just a bruise and a dazed look. I promised I'd be back. I always keep my promises.

After he left the clinic, I followed him closely. He held a piece of paper, damp from sweat, trembling fingers gripping a diagnosis apparently something called "atherosclerosis" I don't know what it is exactly but he was told to get treated immediately or risk dying. I already knew he would die in two days, to be exact.

Ibtisam wasn't superstitious, but he believed in herbal cures. Through a friend, he heard that powdered Ajwa date seeds could heal the heart. He clung to that hope like a man reaching for a vine over a cliff. Again humans. Always trying. Always bargaining.

On the 19th of May, he woke up sweating, his heart struggling already. He skipped breakfast well, unless you count a glass of milk. After that, he stepped out to buy the powder, and I followed. He never had the manners to leave the door open for me. I had to climb over the brown front gate. I like when things are simple, you know. But Ibtisam never made anything simple.

The market wasn't far, just twenty minutes on foot, but Ibtisam was already breathless halfway through. I had seen him climb hills with Faiza once, laughing, breathless from joy not weakness. Now he could barely keep pace with his own shadow. It made me... sad. Or as close as I can feel to sadness.

The scent of cardamom and roasted dates lingered in the air, mixing with the warmth of the May sun and the soft hush of the waking city. The stalls were half-open, lights flickering like the last breaths of small lives. I stood by the figs and dry fruits vendor, inspecting the ripeness of time. And at last, he came.

He saw me before I spoke. Always surprises me, that. Most expect thunder. But I don't wear a cloak or carry a scythe. Just a dusty coat and tired eyes.

"I knew you'd come," he said, still sorting the dates, not looking up.

I stopped time. Like I always do, when someone is worth listening to. Most scream or bargain. But sometimes, a soul like Ibtisam comes along. Someone worth listening to.

"I'm never early," I said. "Today just happens to be the day."

He gave a small, tired smile. "I thought maybe I'd forget you."

"No one forgets me," I replied. "But they often pretend."

We stood quietly, surrounded by the unraveling world. Tarps being pulled down. Children darting past. A distant call to prayer from a nearby minaret.

"You thought of Faiza before I arrived," I said.

He flinched, the name hitting like a pebble to glass.

"You see everything, don't you?"

"I see enough. Enough to know you're wondering whether you owe her something."

"She loved me," he whispered. "And I never... I never gave her what she hoped for."

"She didn't love you because she expected something in return."

"That's not fair," he said. "You make it sound noble. But it hurt her. My silence. My distance."

"It did," I said. "But love that costs nothing isn't worth much. And Faiza paid dearly to love you."

"She'll never know how much I admired her," he murmured. "How fiercely she lived. How she looked at me like I was someone even when I felt like nothing."

"Then why think of her now?" I asked.

“Because... if I have any regret, it’s not that I didn’t love her the way she loved me. It’s that I never told her what her love meant. Even if I couldn’t give it back.”

“You can still tell her.”

He looked up at me, eyes glistening.

“How? Aren’t we going somewhere I can’t return from?”

“You’re right. You’ll never see her again. And she’ll never see you. You’re out of time.”

And there it was the weight of goodbye. Tears fell. Softly. Silently.

“But people carry what we give them and what we fail to. Silence echoes louder than farewells. I can carry your words to her. If you want.”

Ibtisam hesitated, pain deepening in his eyes.

“Now is the time,” I said. “If not for yourself, then for Faiza.”

He closed his eyes, and spoke:

“Tell her I never took her for granted. Tell her she made me feel seen when I felt invisible. Tell her I loved her not the way she wanted, but in the only way I could. And I’m sorry.”

I looked at him. And for a moment, the weight of his eternity passed through me like wind through open windows.

We began our walk not toward light or darkness. Just toward death.

I smiled.

“She’ll hear,” I said.